

# Time Tracking, Dopamine Menus, and Executive Function Tools

FOR A FOCUS SYSTEM  
60-minute lesson plan



## Time Tracking, Dopamine Menus, and Executive Function Tools for a Focus System

| Lesson detail | Information                                                                                                                    |
|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Audience      | Teens or adults                                                                                                                |
| Duration      | 60 minutes                                                                                                                     |
| Subject       | Time awareness, executive function, and personal focus systems                                                                 |
| Date          | _____                                                                                                                          |
| Goal          | Build a personal, low-pressure focus system using time awareness, executive-function supports, and planned restorative breaks. |

### Guiding approach

Treat time tracking as information, not a judgment. Learners will test supports, notice

what helps, and adjust their system without requiring perfect productivity.

## Learning objectives

By the end of the lesson, learners will be able to:

1. Notice how they currently spend time without judgment by reconstructing recent activities in rough time blocks.
2. Identify one executive-function barrier, such as starting, planning, sustaining attention, switching, or estimating time.
3. Create a personalized dopamine menu with time-limited options and return cues for restorative breaks.
4. Practise the repeatable cycle Plan → Focus → Reset → Review and select a support to try again.

## Materials and resources

- ☐ Paper or digital planner
- ☐ Timer or timer app
- ☐ Sticky notes or highlighters
- ☐ Focus-system worksheet
- ☐ A quiet surface or workspace for the practice sprint

## Standards alignment

| Skill area                | Alignment in this lesson                                                                                     |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Self-management           | Learners observe their time use, choose a manageable focus length, and plan a restart.                       |
| Planning and organization | Learners name a task, identify the smallest next action, and use a later list for distractions.              |
| Metacognition             | Learners compare planned and actual time, rate focus, and reflect on what supported them.                    |
| Well-being and autonomy   | Learners select restorative breaks that fit their needs without treating productivity as a measure of worth. |

# Lesson procedure

## 1. Opener: “Where did the time go?” – 10 minutes

Purpose: Activate time awareness without introducing pressure or self-criticism.

1. Ask learners to reconstruct the last two hours in rough time blocks. Approximate categories are enough; exact minutes are not required.
2. Invite learners to mark one block when they felt focused and one block that took longer than expected.
3. Discuss: What took longer than expected? When did you feel most focused? What interrupted you? What helped you restart?
4. Ask for optional pair or whole-group sharing. Accept “I do not know yet” as a valid response.

Transition: Explain that the next activity turns observations into practical external supports.

### Teacher note

Say: “Time tracking is data collection, not a test of productivity. We are looking for patterns and possible supports, not reasons to criticize ourselves.”

## 2. Mini-lesson: “Executive function and time” – 10 minutes

Explain that executive function includes skills used to start, plan, sustain attention, switch, remember, and estimate time. Focus difficulties can indicate a need for external supports—not laziness.

| Challenge            | Helpful external tool                     |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Starting a task      | Two-minute starter step                   |
| Losing track of time | Visible timer or alarm                    |
| Too many tasks       | “Top 1 task” list                         |
| Getting distracted   | Phone out of reach or a website blocker   |
| Difficulty switching | Transition alarm plus a written next step |
| Forgetting plans     | Visual schedule or sticky note            |

## Principle to remember

“Make the task visible, small, timed, and supported.” Ask learners which part of this principle would help most with their current barrier.

### 3. Activity: Build a dopamine menu – 15 minutes

Explain that a dopamine menu is a pre-selected list of quick, healthy, enjoyable activities chosen ahead of time. It makes a supportive break easier to choose when focus drops and reduces decision fatigue. It is a planning tool, not a medical treatment or a promise of a specific neurochemical effect.

Instructions:

1. Ask learners to choose activities they genuinely find restorative, accessible, and appropriate for their setting.
2. Have learners add at least two options to each menu section, adapting examples as needed.
3. Require every item to include a time limit and a return cue.

| Menu section | Time or use                                   | Examples                                                        |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Starters     | 1–5 minutes                                   | Stretching, water, one song, stepping outside, doodling         |
| Sides        | Usable during work; set a check-in or end cue | Instrumental music, a fidget, tea, a body double, standing desk |
| Mains        | 10–30 minutes                                 | Walk, shower, hobby, calling a friend, exercise                 |
| Desserts     | Use intentionally with a timer                | Short video, game, social media with a timer                    |
| Specials     | Planned rewards                               | Movie night, outing, favourite meal                             |

## Menu rule

Every item needs a time limit and a return cue. Example: “When the timer ends, I reopen my task list.” A break is successful when it restores choice and makes returning easier—

not when it looks perfectly productive.

Share and check: In pairs, learners explain one Starter or Side they could use during a difficult work block and name its return cue.

## 4. Build the focus system – 15 minutes

Present the cycle as a flexible routine learners can repeat and adjust.

1. Plan – 2 minutes. Name the task, write the smallest next action, choose a focus length of 10, 15, or 25 minutes, and select one support tool.
2. Focus. Start the timer. Keep only needed materials visible. Capture distracting thoughts or tasks on a “later list” instead of following them immediately.
3. Reset – 3–10 minutes. Choose one timed Starter or Side from the dopamine menu. Keep the break bounded and use the return cue.
4. Review – 1 minute. Record what was completed, identify the next visible step, and decide whether the focus block was too long, too short, or about right.

Teacher move: Model one example aloud, then give learners time to complete their own worksheet. Offer a verbal rehearsal for anyone who finds writing difficult.

### Focus-system worksheet

| Prompt                  | Learner response                                  |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| My task                 | _____                                             |
| My smallest next action | _____                                             |
| My focus length         | 10 minutes / 15 minutes / 25 minutes              |
| My support tool         | _____                                             |
| What I completed        | _____                                             |
| My next visible step    | _____                                             |
| Block-length reflection | Too long / Too short / About right. Why?<br>_____ |

## 5. Practice focus sprint — 8 minutes

Ask learners to choose a small, clearly bounded task. Have them set up the Plan step, work silently for 8 minutes, and use their selected support. At the end, ask them to record:

- ☐ Planned time: \_\_\_\_ minutes
- ☐ Actual time: \_\_\_\_ minutes
- ☐ Focus rating, 1–5: \_\_\_\_
- ☐ Support used: \_\_\_\_\_
- ☐ Next step: \_\_\_\_\_

Transition: Invite learners to notice what they learned about their time, barrier, or support before completing the exit ticket.

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## 6. Exit ticket — 2 minutes

Complete: “When I notice I am stuck, I will use \_\_\_\_\_ for \_\_\_\_ minutes, then return by \_\_\_\_\_.”

## Assessment

Formative checks during the lesson:

☐ Review the opener record for a genuine attempt to notice time use without judgment.  
☐ Listen for each learner naming one executive-function barrier and a matching external support.

☐ Check that each dopamine-menu option has a time limit and a return cue.

☐ Observe whether learners can state the four parts of Plan → Focus → Reset → Review.

End-of-lesson evidence: Review the worksheet and exit ticket. Each learner should produce:

- ☒ ~~One time-tracking record~~
- ☒ ~~One personalized dopamine menu~~
- ☒ ~~One focus cycle to try today~~
- ☒ ~~One specific restart plan for when attention slips~~

Success criteria: The plan is specific enough to try, flexible enough to adjust, and supportive rather than punitive. Learners do not need to complete a large amount of work to meet the criteria.

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## Differentiation and access

| Learner need                           | Support or extension                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Learners who are struggling            | Offer a shorter focus block, such as 2–5 minutes; provide one example at a time; use a partially completed worksheet; and allow movement-based resets.                     |
| Learners working at the expected level | Invite them to choose a 10-, 15-, or 25-minute block, select a support independently, and explain their return cue to a partner.                                           |
| Learners seeking extension             | Compare planned versus actual time across several focus blocks, look for patterns, and revise the chosen focus length or support tool.                                     |
| Visual or verbal support needs         | Give directions in both visual and spoken form, model the cycle, use color-coded prompts, and permit verbal responses or dictation.                                        |
| Social or attention support needs      | Offer partner or body-double support, a quiet workspace, instrumental music, or a visible timer.                                                                           |
| English Language Learners              | Pre-teach barrier, support, reset, return cue, and estimate; provide sentence frames; pair words with icons or examples; and accept home-language planning where possible. |

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## Reflection and notes

Learner reflection

What did I notice about my time or attention?

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Which support felt most useful, and what will I test next?

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What would make my system easier or kinder to use?

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Facilitator reflection

Which instructions or examples helped learners begin?

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Where did learners need more modeling, time, movement, or choice?

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What will I adjust before teaching this lesson again?

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Editable daily tracker

Use one row for each focus block. Record approximate information; the purpose is to notice patterns, not to produce perfect data.

| Focus block | Task  | Planned / actual time | Tool used | Energy before / after |
|-------------|-------|-----------------------|-----------|-----------------------|
| 1           | _____ | ___ / ___ min         | _____     | ___ / ___             |
| 2           | _____ | ___ / ___ min         | _____     | ___ / ___             |
| 3           | _____ | ___ / ___ min         | _____     | ___ / ___             |